



WHISPERING RIVER MEDIA
DOCUMENTARY SHORT · 2026

DEATH OF A GLACIER

A FILM BY ETHAN C. PARRISH, PH.D.

High in the Bolivian Andes, the scientists who study the disappearing glaciers and the communities whose water depends on them confront what is being lost — and the question of what can still be saved.

SPECIFICATIONS

RUNTIME	16:46
FORMAT	Documentary Short
YEAR	2026
ASPECT RATIO	2.35 : 1
LANGUAGE	Spanish & English with subtitles
COUNTRY	USA / Bolivia

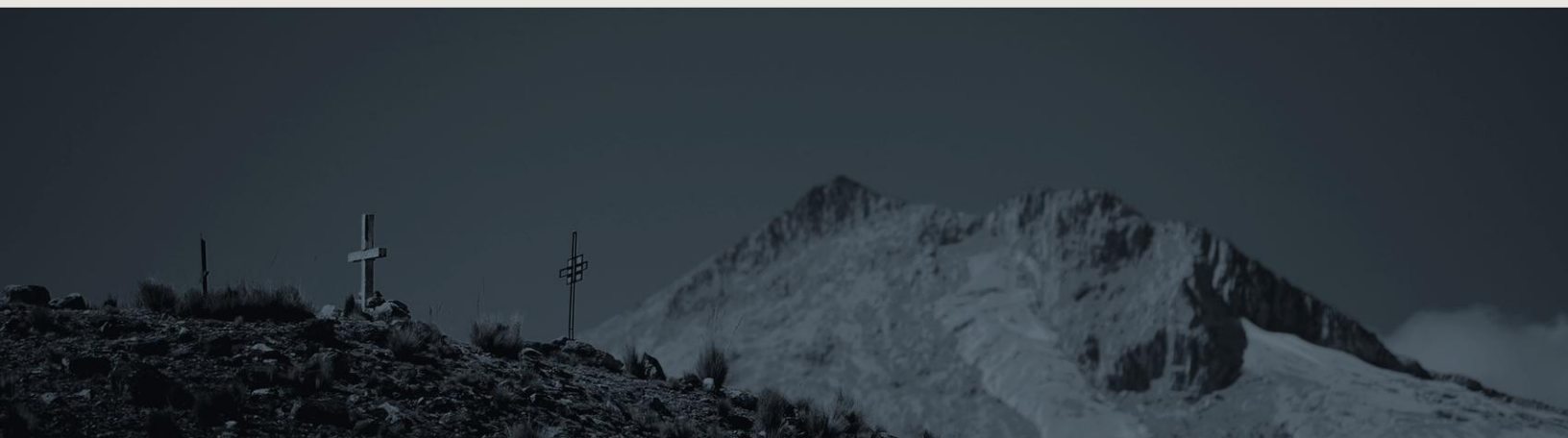
PRESS · SALES · BOOKING

Ethan C. Parrish, Ph.D.

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whisperingrivermedia.com/deathofaglacier

00:33 · CROSSES ABOVE THE ZONGO VALLEY





01:22 · ICEFALL, HUAYNA POTOSÍ

02 SYNOPSIS

In the Bolivian Andes, the glaciers are vanishing — and with them, the water that sustains the communities below. *Death of a Glacier* follows a team of climate scientists and the residents of the Zongo Valley as they confront the retreat of ice that has crowned these mountains for millennia. For the families living at the foot of Huayna Potosí, the glacier is drinking water, electricity, livelihood, and memory. For the scientists, it is a record — one that now shows the ice has shrunk past its smallest size in nearly twelve thousand years.

Told largely in Spanish by the people closest to the loss, the film moves from why glaciers matter, to what the science reveals, to the harder question of what remains possible. It refuses both denial and despair, insisting that what we still do counts.

"Maybe I will be the first to have no water — because I live so high up."

DOMITILA ALAÑA LLUSCO · ZONGO VALLEY



14:03 · HUAYNA POTOSÍ & THE ZONGO VALLEY



11:01 · FIELDWORK BELOW THE GLACIER



07:06 · DOMITILA ALAÑA LLUSCO



00:53 · ADRIÁN VARGAS QUISPE



05:25 · MELTWATER

PORTRAIT
[TK]

Dr. Andrew Jones

CLIMATOLOGIST · UW-MADISON · LEAD SUBJECT

Climatologist at UW–Madison whose proglacial team conducts the glacier-monitoring fieldwork at the film's center. On screen he carries the science — cosmogenic nuclide dating, the 11,700-year retreat threshold — and the film's emotional spine, naming the ecological dread of a warming world while rejecting climate fatalism.

PORTRAIT
[TK]

Álvaro Soruco

GLACIOLOGIST · BOLIVIAN COLLABORATOR

Glaciologist studying glacial mass balance — the budget of ice gain and loss. He provides the Bolivian scientific grounding for the project and explains the glaciers' vital role in supplying water to La Paz and El Alto.

PORTRAIT
[TK]

Yasmeen Orellana-Salazar

PH.D. STUDENT & RESEARCHER · UW-MADISON

Chilean geologist whose research reconstructs how glaciers around Andean volcanoes have responded to climate change, reading the landscapes left behind by past ice. She is committed to helping communities connect with the geological history of where they live.

PORTRAIT
[TK]

Matías Romero

FIELD RESEARCHER · JONES TEAM

Field researcher with the UW–Madison proglacial lab, working alongside Jones and Orellana–Salazar throughout the Bolivia expedition.

PORTRAIT
[TK]

Domitila Alaña Llusco

MOUNTAIN GUIDE · ZONGO VALLEY

Has guided near Huayna Potosí for two decades and co-founded Cholitas Escaladoras, the collective of Indigenous Bolivian women who climb the high peaks in traditional dress — a first-hand witness to the glacier's retreat.

PORTRAIT
[TK]

Adrián Vargas Quispe

AYMARA MOUNTAIN GUIDE · ZONGO VALLEY

Has led climbing parties up Huayna Potosí and the Cordillera Real for seventeen years. Living at the foot of the mountain, he sees the glacier's retreat as a daily reality for the water his family depends on.



Ethan C. Parrish

Ph.D.

DIRECTOR · PRODUCER · DP · EDITOR

Ethan is a documentary filmmaker and geoscientist based in Wenatchee, Washington. He holds a Ph.D. in geoscience from UW–Madison, where his research spanned ancient hydrologic systems and the affective impact of art-integrated science education — a throughline that runs directly into his filmmaking. His films center on earth science and our physical relationship with the planet, built around people rather than data.

He directed, shot, and edited *Death of a Glacier* — his second original documentary short, following *What's in a Name?* (2024), a film about decolonizing the science of paleontology.

Whispering River Media

Whispering River Media is the independent documentary practice of Ethan C. Parrish, Ph.D. Based in Wenatchee, Washington, Whispering River Media makes character-driven films about earth and physical science — work that illuminates the interconnectedness of humanity and the planet, pairing scientific rigor with emotional storytelling to make complex environmental stories legible to broad audiences.



A QUESTION ABOUT DEATH

Death of a Glacier began not on a mountain but at the University of Wisconsin–Madison, inside an interdisciplinary initiative built around a single question: how do human beings make sense of death? It examined mortality across three scales — the individual, the civilizational, and the geological. One strand reached into the earth sciences, where the retreat of glaciers offered a stark new way to think about an ending: not of a person, but of a landscape, and perhaps of a planet.

A TWO-PART FILM

The project unfolds in two parts, each shot on a research expedition supported by the UW–Madison proglacial lab. Part one — Death of a Glacier (Iceland), released in fall 2024 — is a short, lyrical meditation on glacial loss. Part two, the subject of this kit, travels to the Bolivian Andes, where the science sharpens and the human stakes come into focus. Together the films move from elegy to inquiry — from feeling the loss to understanding it, and asking what can still be done.

WHY THIS STORY

Framing a glacier's retreat as a death makes room for grief without surrendering to despair — and for the insistence, shared by scientists and community members alike, that an ending is not the same as an inevitability.

SUPPORTED BY

- University of Wisconsin–Madison Proglacial Lab
- Part 1 streaming — Death of a Glacier (Iceland) · youtu.be/o20ekRI65Xc

12:28 · THE NEXT GENERATION, ZONGO VALLEY



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